

***South-central Regional Hearing on Congressional
Redistricting; Presented October 13, 2021; York, Pennsylvania
Presented by: Ben Thomas Jr. Mayor – Borough of Greencastle,
Franklin County, Pennsylvania***

My name is Ben Thomas, Jr. I am the Mayor of Greencastle, Franklin County, PA and the Municipal Manager / Chief Administrative Officer of Cumberland Township, Adams County, surrounding the Borough of Gettysburg and host to the Gettysburg Military Park. Each municipality is close to and adjacent to the Maryland (Mason-Dixon) line. Greencastle's population is around 4,000 and encompasses 1.6 square miles of urban homes (owner and rental occupancy) businesses and industries. We are along the I-81 corridor. Cumberland Township is near U.S. Route 15 where annual tourism is approximately three million. Growth all around Greencastle is exploding with warehousing, residential, and commercial development. Cumberland Township is a bedroom community with high density housing and rentals being constructed by the hundreds.

Though Pennsylvania's population may be shrinking, south-central and south-eastern Pennsylvania's population demographics are increasing. Franklin County is the 10th fastest growing County by population in the Commonwealth. Folks are moving from urban cities to our areas where they can retire with lower tax obligations or rent / purchase properties while working from home placing their children in better public-school systems. New residents are finding a much higher quality of life with lower costs of living. For the following

reasons it is imperative that any redistricting decisions provide us with ample representation as the need for our continued quality of life may be sustained:

1. Public education as the population will demand more schools, faculty, support staff, and operational costs.
2. Ample infrastructure; water, sewer, broadband, transportation systems including the widening of Interstate-81 that may not occur until the 2030s'.
3. Appropriate public safety as there are few volunteers left to provide fire, rescue, and emergency medical services that requires "paid or career" staffing that is now being implemented in the Greencastle community. I have volunteered as a firefighter and emergency medical technician and/or active member for 48 years. The changes and costs I am witnessing are very concerning.
4. The need for more police services as some sectors of the Pa. municipal police system are very antiquated. Municipal police can't even use radar or state of the art LIDAR for speed, safety enforcement. Borough budgets are getting even tighter though Boroughs are required to provide more services as the surrounding townships grow, take in the tax revenues, and may provide limited services. It's not the Township's fault. That is the Pennsylvania system. Boroughs are typically the centralized hubs that will not grow in size as annexation in Pennsylvania is all but extinct. Therefore, Boroughs provide infrastructure to surrounding townships without the benefit of receiving the tax base as is the practice in most other states.

In summary, it is imperative that municipalities like the Borough of Greencastle, Franklin County, and Cumberland Township, Adams County, receive ample

representation from Washington, DC and from Harrisburg, PA for our future quality of life and financial sustainability.

Respectfully,

Mayor Ben Thomas, Jr. Greencastle, Pennsylvania